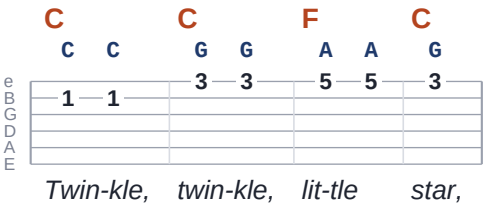
Guitar Songbook

Beginner Grade 1 • 15 songs with chords, melody tab and words

How to read each line

Chord	Strum this chord from the start of the group.
Note	The melody note name (same letters as the keyboard book). A dash means hold the note before it.
Tab	Six lines = six strings, high e on top, low E at the bottom. The number is the fret to press; 0 = open string. Play the numbers left to right.
Words	Sing one syllable per note.

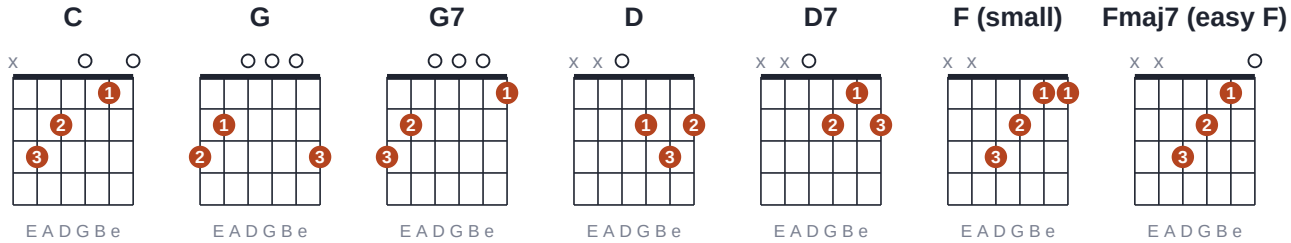
Example (first line of Twinkle Twinkle):



All melodies stay in **first position** (frets 0 to 4, plus fret 5 once or twice), so the fretting hand never has to move. Use finger 1 for fret 1, finger 2 for fret 2, finger 3 for fret 3, finger 4 for fret 4.

Chord shapes

Dots show where to press, with the finger number inside (1 = index ... 4 = little). o = play the open string, x = don't play that string.



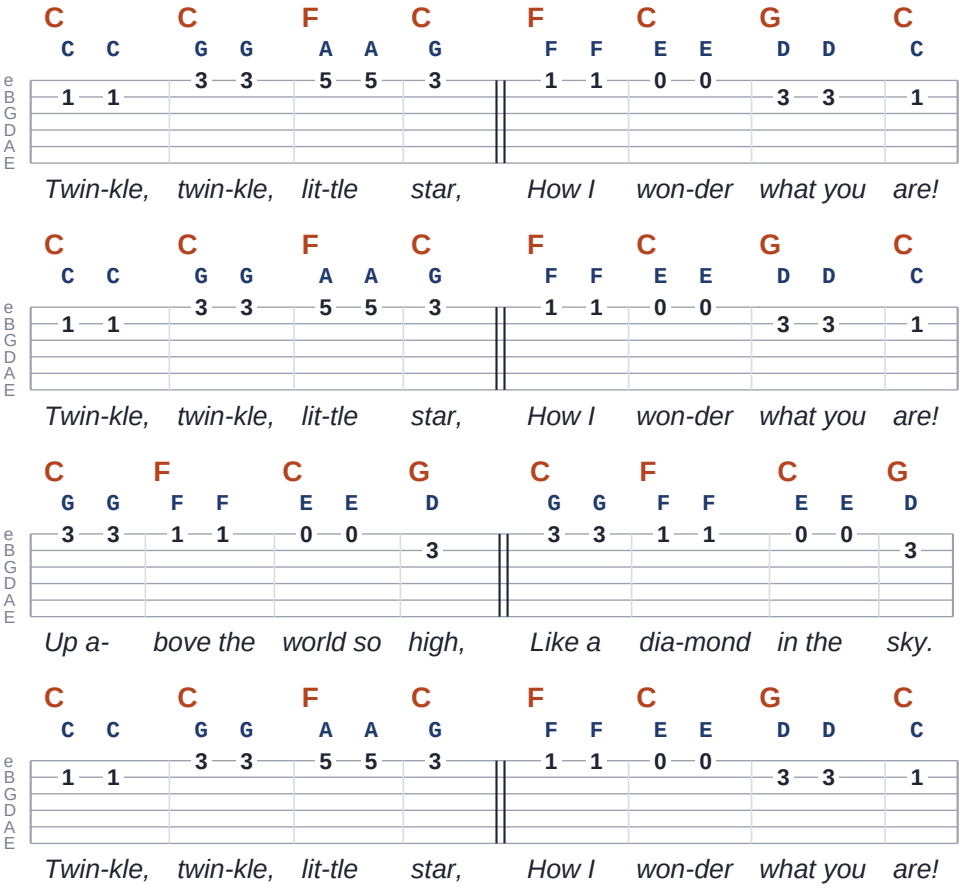
F tip: full F needs a barre, which is hard for beginners. Use the small F (index finger presses the top two strings at fret 1) or the even easier Fmaj7, which sounds almost the same in these songs.

Songs

01 Twinkle Twinkle Little Star	**09** Wheels on the Bus
02 Mary Had a Little Lamb	**10** Bits of Paper
03 London Bridge	**11** Row Row Row Your Boat
04 God is so Good	**12** Jingle Bells (Half Version)
05 Baa Baa Black Sheep	**13** National Anthem: Jana Gana Mana (Full)
06 Happy Birthday to You	**14** Yankee Doodle
07 Jesus Loves Me	**15** Lightly Row
08 Old MacDonald	

01. Twinkle Twinkle Little Star

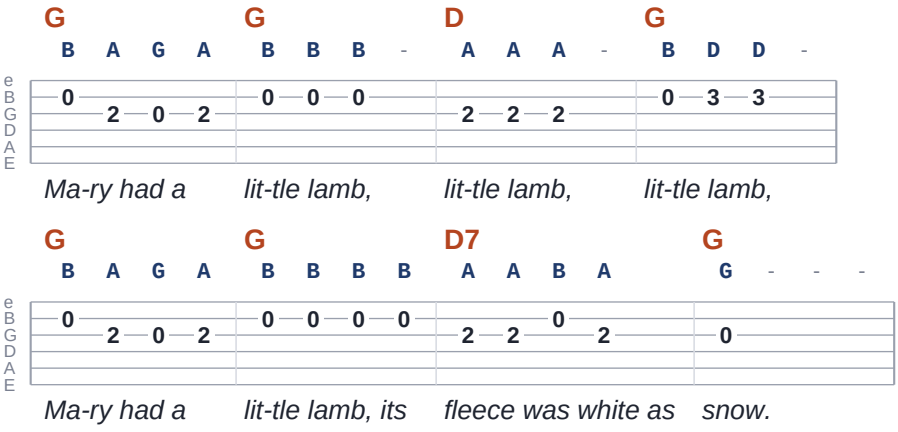
Key: **C major** | Chords: **C, F, G**



• *Each chord lasts for one pair of notes. Strum once per note, or once per pair for a slower feel.*

02. Mary Had a Little Lamb

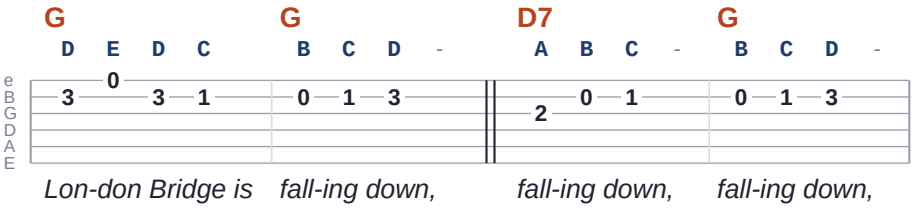
Key: **G major** | Chords: **G, D (or D7)**



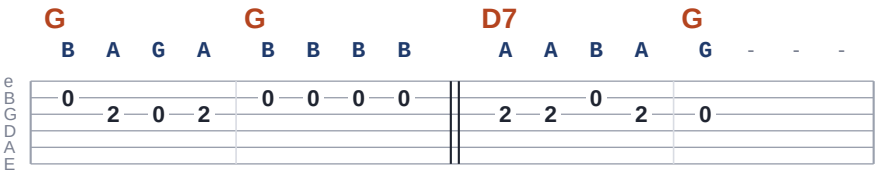
• *D7 on "fleece was white as" gives a stronger pull into the final G.*

03. London Bridge

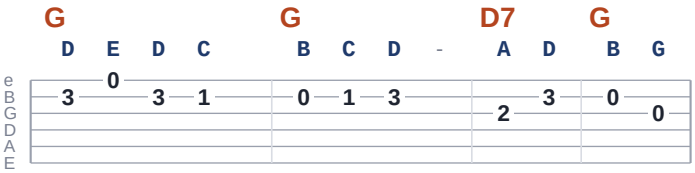
Key: **G major** | Chords: **G, D7**



Lon-don Bridge is fall-ing down, fall-ing down, fall-ing down,



Usual ending (to sing with the words)



Lon-don Bridge is fall-ing down, my fair la-dy.

> • *Lines 3 and 4 in the book use the same notes as the ending of Mary Had a Little Lamb, so the words don't fit them. Use the usual ending below to sing the song.*

04. God is so Good

Key: **G major** | Chords: **G, C, D, D7**

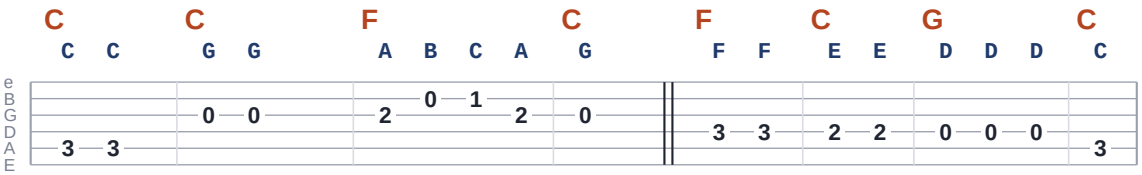
God is so good, God is so good,

God is so good, He's so good to me.

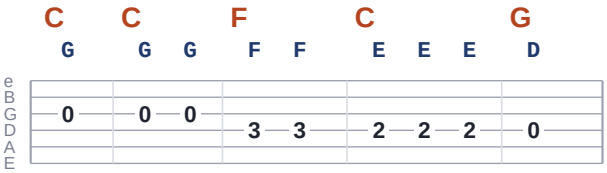
> • *On "to me", play D7 on "to" and change to G on "me".*

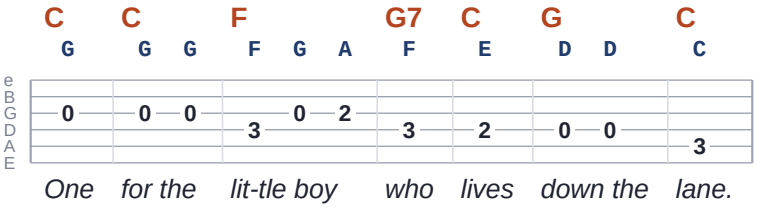
05. Baa Baa Black Sheep

Key: **C major** | Chords: **C, F, G, G7**



Baa, baa, black sheep, have you a-ny wool? Yes sir, yes sir, three bags full.

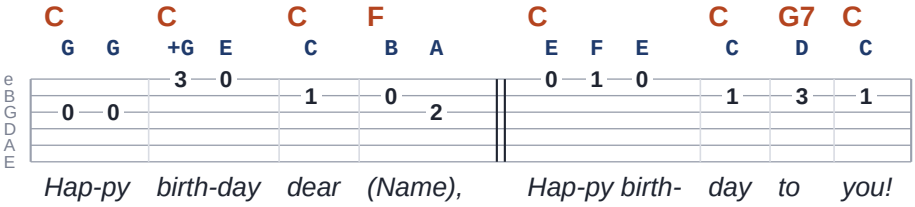




- *Same melody family as Twinkle Twinkle, so the chord pattern feels familiar.*
- *For F, use the small F or the easy Fmaj7 shape from the chord page.*

06. Happy Birthday to You

Key: **C major** | Chords: **C, F, G7**

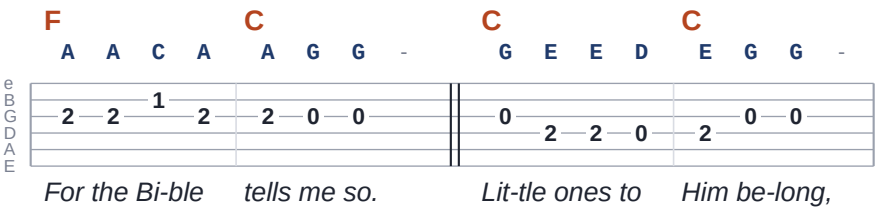


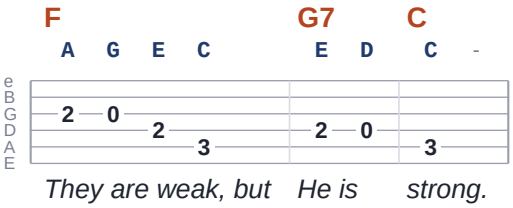
- *The jump on line 3 ("birth-day") is the big moment of the song: the tab climbs to the 3rd fret of the high e string.*
- *The usual tune starts the last line with F F E. If you play it that way, use F on "Hap-py".*

07. Jesus Loves Me

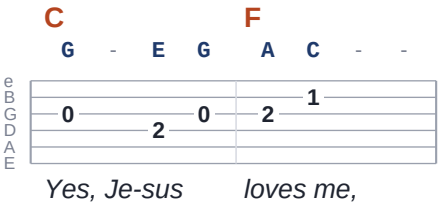
Key: **C major** | Chords: **C, F, G, G7**

Verse





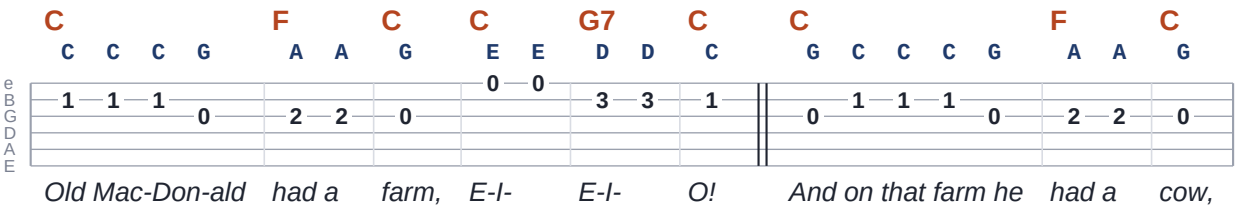
Chorus

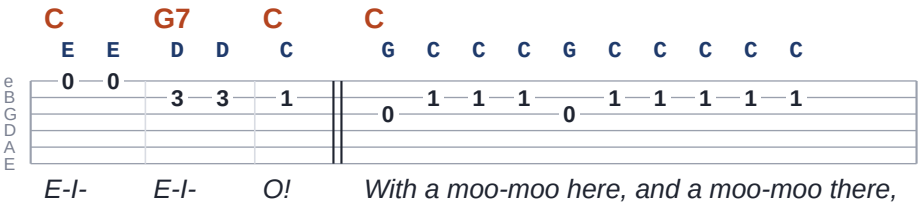


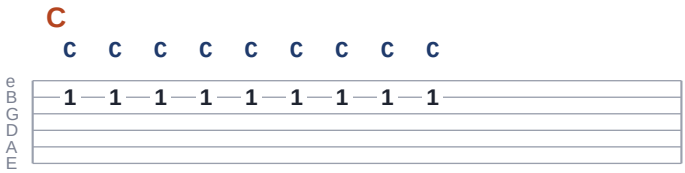
• *For F, use the small F or the easy Fmaj7 shape from the chord page.*

08. Old MacDonald

Key: **C major** | Chords: **C, F, G7**







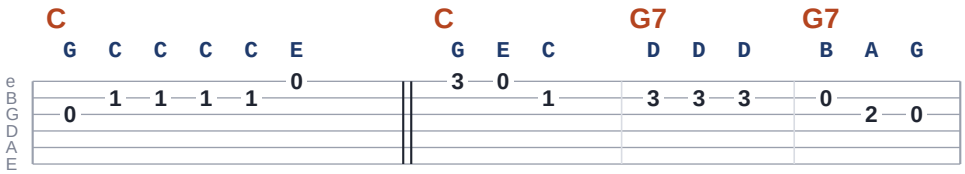
Here a moo, there a moo, ev-ery-where a moo-moo,

Old Mac-Don-ald had a farm, E-I- E-I- O!

• *Lines 4 and 5 have fewer notes than words: sing quick words like "with a" and "and a" together on one note. Keep strumming C through both lines.*

09. Wheels on the Bus

Key: **C major** | Chords: **C, G7** | Notes from the book, with new practice words



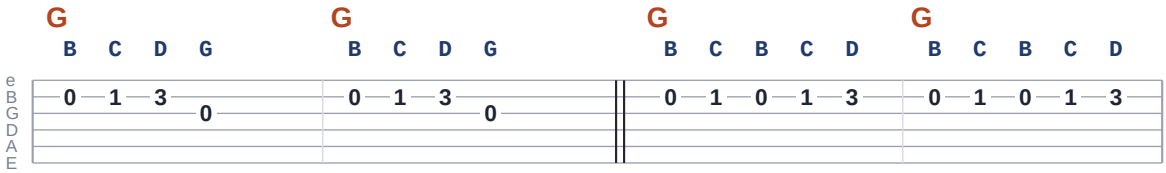
Let's all play the key-board, Thumb is one, pin-ky's five, here we go!

Fin-gers on the key-board, Up and down the keys we play all day long!

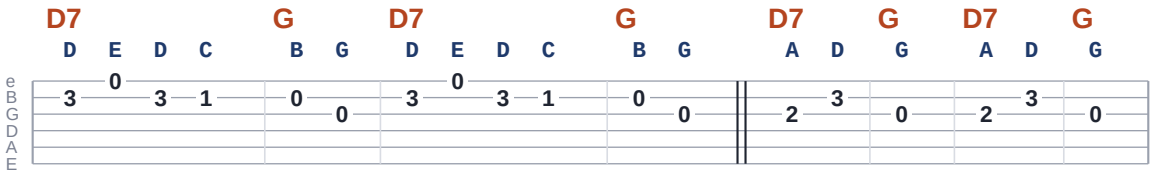
• *These are original practice words that fit the notes one syllable per note. Students who know the traditional words can sing those with the same notes and chords.*

10. Bits of Paper

Key: **G major** | Chords: **G, D7** | Notes from the book, with new practice words



Clap your hands now, clap your hands now, Sing a hap-py song, sing a hap-py song,

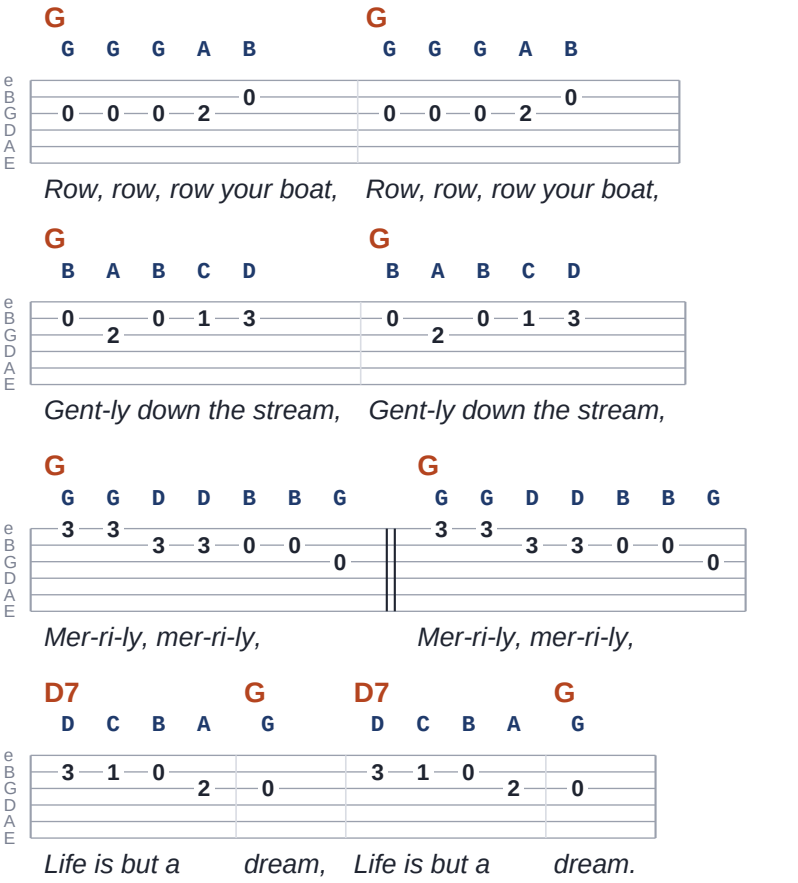


Mu-sic makes us hap-py, mu-sic makes us hap-py, Play a- long, play a- long!

• *Original practice words, one syllable per note. The traditional words can be sung with the same notes and chords.*

11. Row Row Row Your Boat

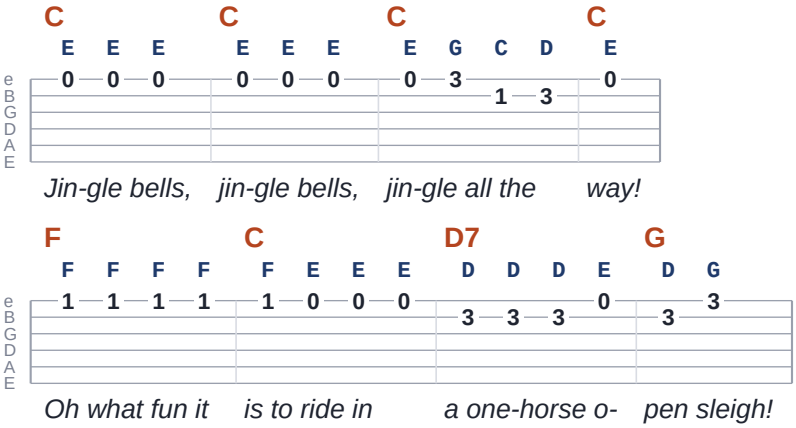
Key: **G major** | Chords: **G, D7**

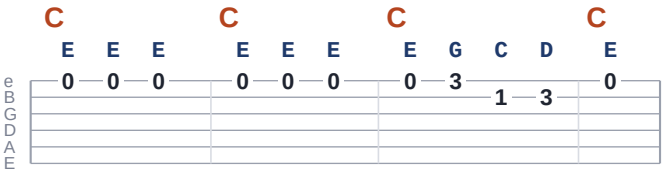


- *The whole song is almost all G: a perfect first strumming song. Change to D7 only on "Life is but a".*

12. Jingle Bells (Half Version)

Key: **C major** | Chords: **C, F, D7, G, G7**





Jin-gle bells, jin-gle bells, jin-gle all the way!

Oh what fun it is to ride in a one-horse o-pen sleigh!

• *Line 2 ends on D7 to G, which leaves the music hanging. Line 4 ends on G7 to C, which closes the song.*

13. National Anthem: Jana Gana Mana (Full)

Key: **C (ends on F)** | Chords: **C, F, G, G7, D7**

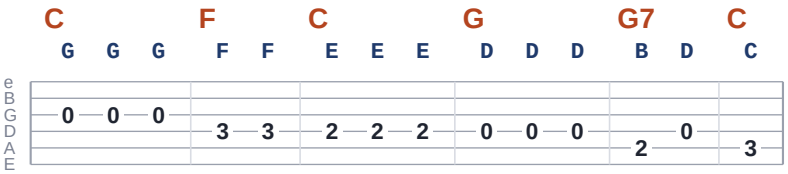
First half (from the book)

Jana gana mana adhinayaka jaya he

Bharata bhagya vidhata

Panjaba Sindhu Gujarata Maratha

Dravida Utkala Banga, Vindhya Himachala



Yamuna Ganga, Uchchhala jaladhi taranga

Second half

Tava shubha name jage,

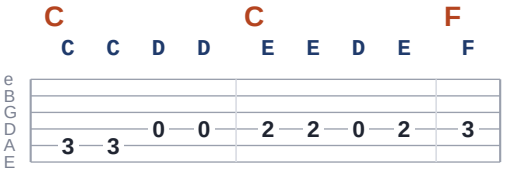
Tava shubha ashisha mage,

Gahe tava jaya gatha.

Jana gana mangala dayaka jaya he

Bharata bhagya vidhata.

Jaya he, jaya he, jaya he,



Jaya jaya jaya jaya he!

- *Lyrics: Rabindranath Tagore. Words are shown under each line; a few syllables stretch across two notes.*
- *The anthem ends on F, so finish on an F chord (small F or Fmaj7).*
- *Second-half notes are adapted from a published beginner melody (piano-keyboard-guide.com), moved from D down to C to match the book.*
- *Strum softly and steadily so the melody stays clear. The full anthem takes about 52 seconds.*

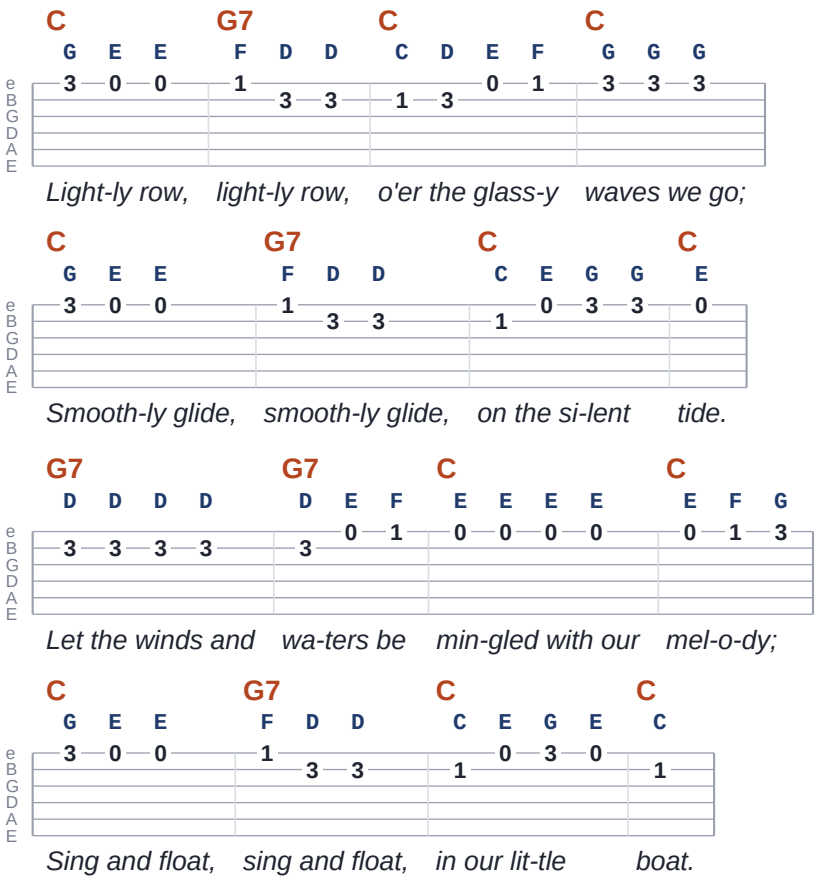
14. Yankee Doodle

Key: **G major** | Chords: **G, C, D, D7**

- *"G to D" means start on G and change to D on the last note ("town").*

15. Lightly Row

Key: **C major** | Chords: **C, G7**



- *Only two chords here, C and G7: great for practising quick, smooth changes.*